

Starting a new role well. The playbook for the first 90 days.

What to do in weeks 1–4, 5–8, and 9–12 of a new role. How to build the relationships that matter. What to do if something feels wrong. How to set yourself up for your first performance review.

IF YOU TAKE NOTHING ELSE AWAY

Five things that matter most

- Weeks 1–4: listen more than you talk. You don't know enough yet to have the right opinions.
- Your first 30 days shape how you're perceived for the first 12 months. Invest in relationships before results.
- Understand what your manager cares most about — and align your visible work to that, not just your job description.
- If something feels wrong in the first 30 days, name it early. Problems that feel small in week two feel enormous in month four.
- Ask your manager in week two: 'What would make the first 90 days a clear success in your view?' Then do those things.

Most professionals start a new role focused on demonstrating their value as fast as possible. The ones who build the most durable success start by listening.

The first 90 days set every pattern that follows. Here's the sequence that works.

WEEKS 1-4: LISTEN, DON'T FIX

Learn before you lead

Have a 30-minute conversation with every person you work with

In the first four weeks, schedule a 1:1 with every direct report, peer, and key stakeholder. Ask: What's working? What's not? What would you do differently if you were in my role? What should I know that I probably don't yet? Listen without defending, disagreeing, or problem-solving. Take notes.

Understand what your manager actually cares about

In week two, ask directly: "What would make the first 90 days a clear success in your view?" Then ask: "What are you most worried about right now?" The answers to these two questions should organize your visible work for the first quarter.

Find the informal power structure

Every organization has a formal org chart and an informal one. Find out: who are the connectors — the people whose support makes things happen? Who are the blockers? Who does your manager listen to? Knowing this in week two saves you from learning it the hard way in month four.

The first 30-day mistake: Announcing everything that's wrong with the current setup before you understand why it's set up that way. Many things that look broken have a reason. Understand the reason before proposing the fix.

WEEKS 5-8: UNDERSTAND THE REAL PROBLEMS

From listening to diagnosis

Synthesize what you've heard into a point of view

By week five, you have enough information to form a working hypothesis about the two or three things that matter most to fix or build. Share your synthesis with your manager: "Here's what I've heard and what I'm making of it. Does this match what you're seeing?" This demonstrates judgment without overreach.

Pick one visible problem to solve

One thing, solved well, builds more credibility than five things addressed partially. Choose something that matters, is achievable in four to six weeks, and is visible to the people whose opinion matters. Deliver it completely.

WEEKS 9-12: DEMONSTRATE JUDGMENT

From diagnosis to results

Make the first recommendation that has a cost or risk

Anyone can make risk-free recommendations. The ones that demonstrate judgment have tradeoffs — resources, priorities, people. By week ten, you should have a recommendation that involves making a real choice. How you present it — the confidence, the reasoning, the acknowledgment of tradeoffs — is what earns trust.

Set up your first performance review before it happens

Two weeks before your first formal review, ask your manager: "I want to make sure I'm focusing on the right things. Would you walk me through how you think about performance at this stage?" The conversation itself signals self-awareness. And you'll learn how to frame your contributions in the review.

If something feels wrong

If the role or the manager is different from what was described — name it early and directly. The conversation you avoid in week six becomes the crisis in month six. "I want to check in on something — I've noticed [specific thing] and I want to understand it better." Most issues that derail new hires could have been addressed with a direct conversation in the first 60 days.

NEXTCAPTER

When you report a hire to NextChapter, Victoria sends you this guide and a week-by-week checklist for the first 90 days. Your search data and everything we learned about your career is saved in your profile — for the next chapter, whenever it comes.

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